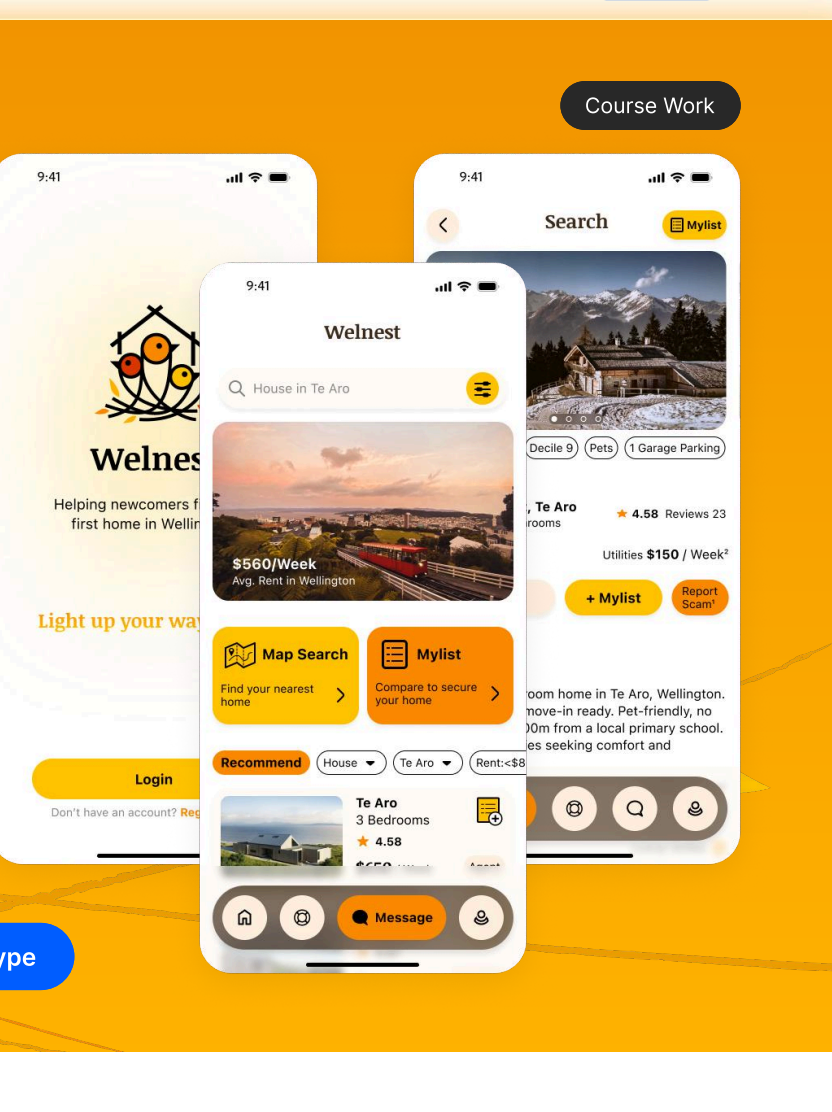
UX Real Estate

Course Work

Welnest

Helping newcomers find a home with clarity and confidence.



View Prototype

Overview

Welnest is a mobile app concept created to support family newcomers in Wellington as they navigate the housing search process. The design focuses on simplifying complex rental steps, providing verified information, and offering empathetic guidance. By combining clarity and trust with an intuitive interface, Welnest aims to make finding a home less overwhelming and more accessible for those settling into a new environment.

Skills

Mixed Methods Research · Information Architecture · User Flow · Prototyping · Usability Testing · Heuristic Evaluation · Accessibility Compliance(WCAG)

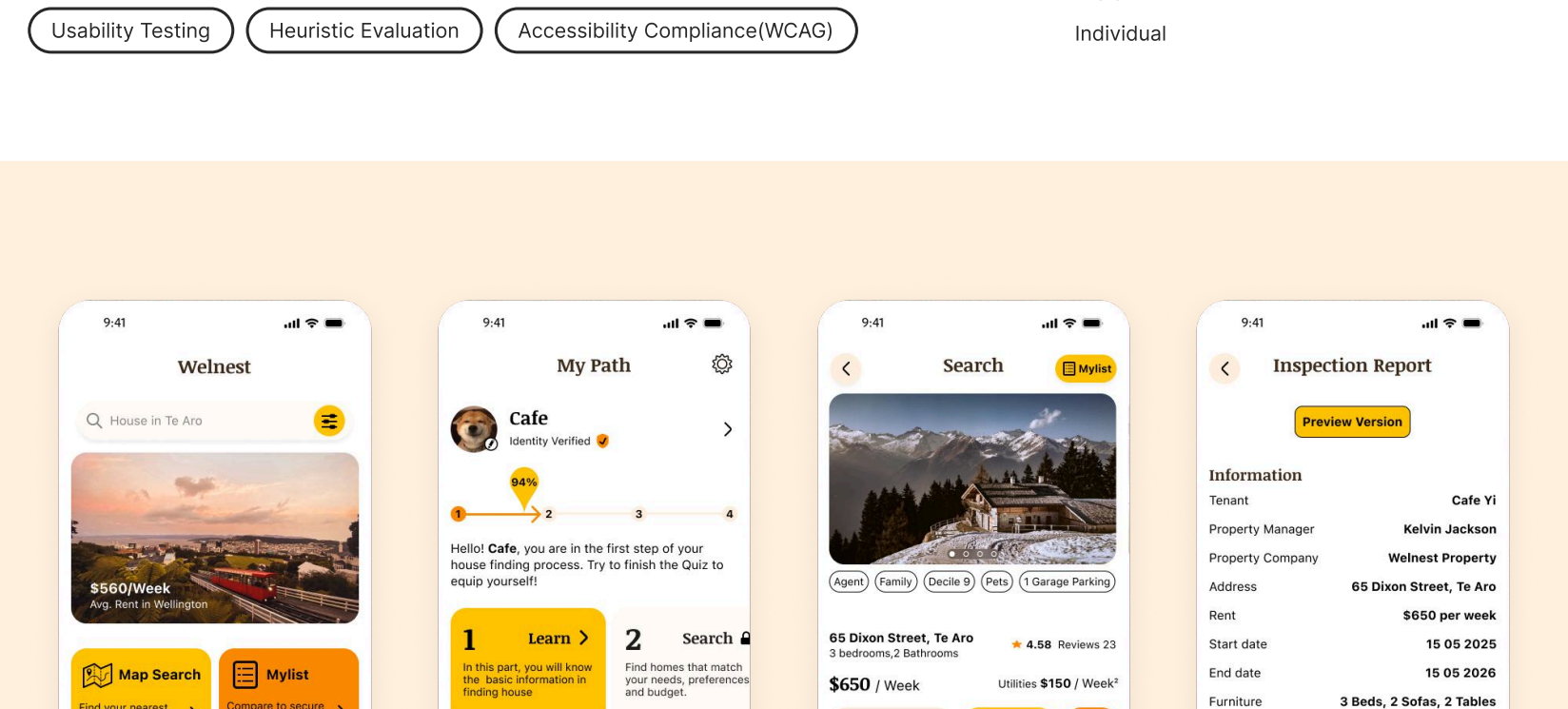
Client
MUXD

Timeline
12 Weeks

Role
UX Research
UX/UI Design
Usability Testing

Tools
Figma
Miro
Office365

Team
Individual



Problem

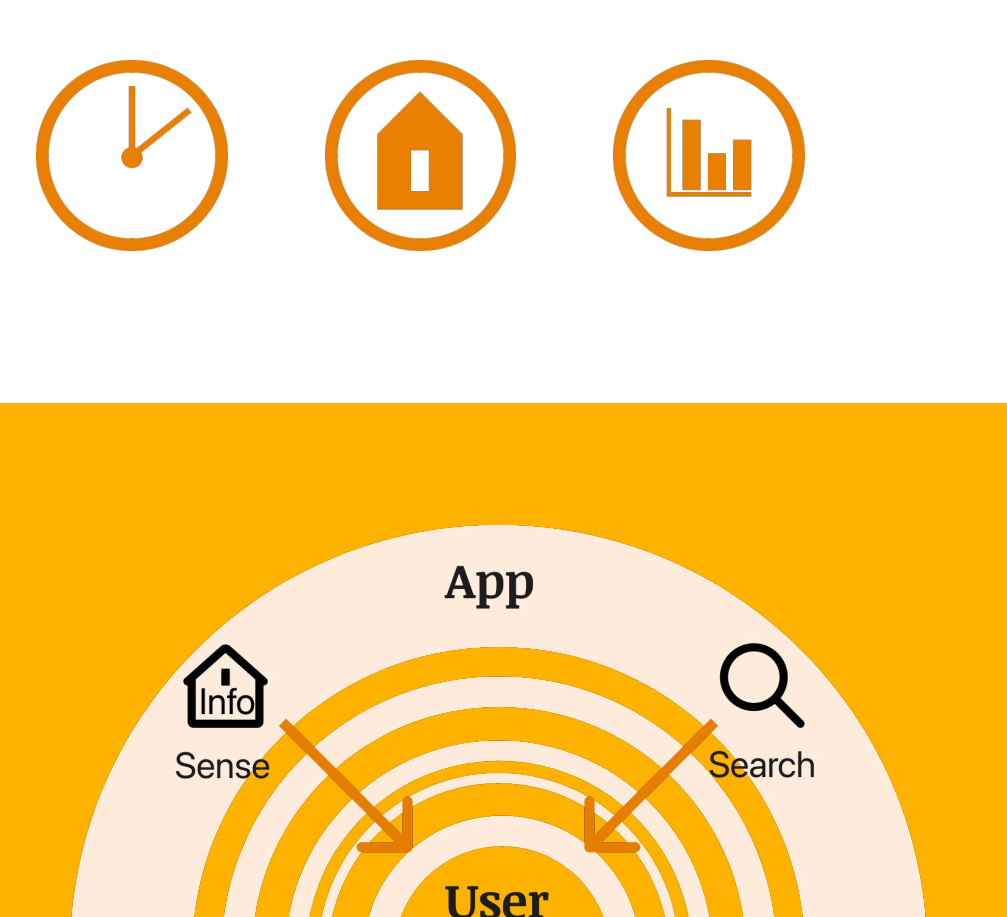
Cost · Time · Complexity · Information · Confidence

Newcomers, especially those arriving with family—face high costs, time pressure, complex rental processes, and information gaps (policies, risks, and support). Tools are fragmented; guidance is inconsistent; confidence in communication with agents/landlords is low.

Solution

Trusted guardian in the housing journey.

Welnest acts as a “guardian” across the journey, providing transparent listings and pricing cues, verified information, empathetic prompts, and lightweight flows for search, comparison, inspection reporting, and support access, all optimized for mobile.



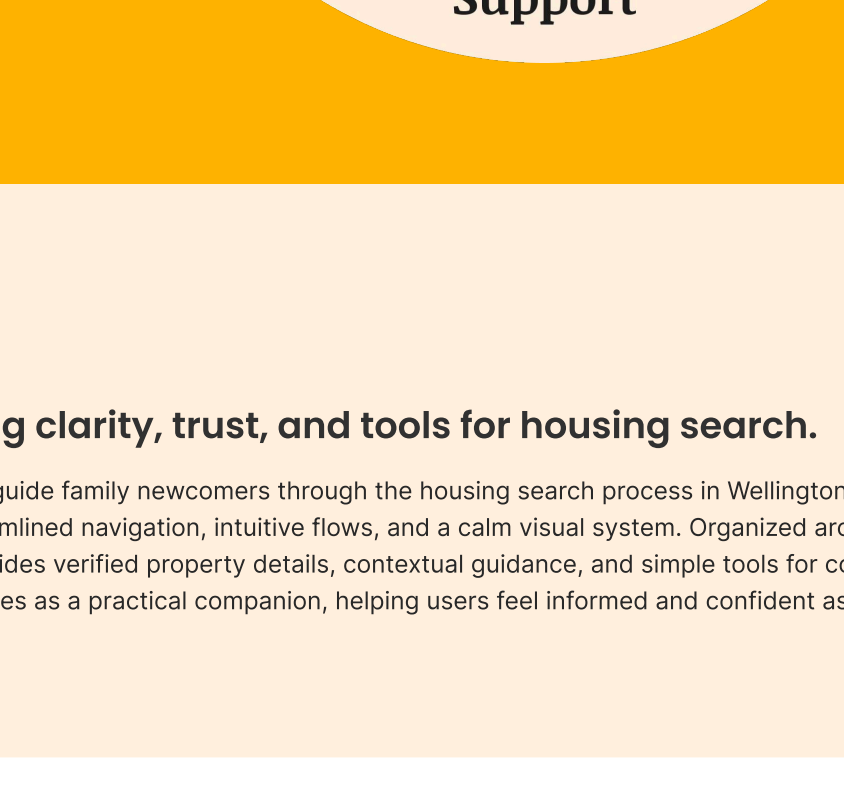
Outcome

A high-fidelity mobile app offering clarity, trust, and tools for housing search.

Welnest is a mobile application concept designed to guide family newcomers through the housing search process in Wellington. The final deliverable is a high-fidelity prototype featuring streamlined navigation, intuitive flows, and a calm visual system. Organized around key user needs—clarity, trust, and support—the app provides verified property details, contextual guidance, and simple tools for comparison and inspection. Tailored for newcomers, Welnest serves as a practical companion, helping users feel informed and confident as they secure a home that meets their family’s needs.

Welnest

Helping newcomers find a home with clarity and confidence.



Feedback

Clear structure, strong testing, and well-documented insights with consistent, accessible design.

> “The case study presents a clear and succinct introduction to the problem and outlines the approach effectively.“

> “The contents page adds structure and makes the presentation easy to follow.”

> “The explanation of user testing is strong, highlighting how feedback was prioritized to ensure efficient iteration. Insights are well-structured, showing before-and-after changes and incorporating user quotes to illustrate decisions.”

> ”The early development of the app concept is engaging and demonstrates thoughtful exploration.“

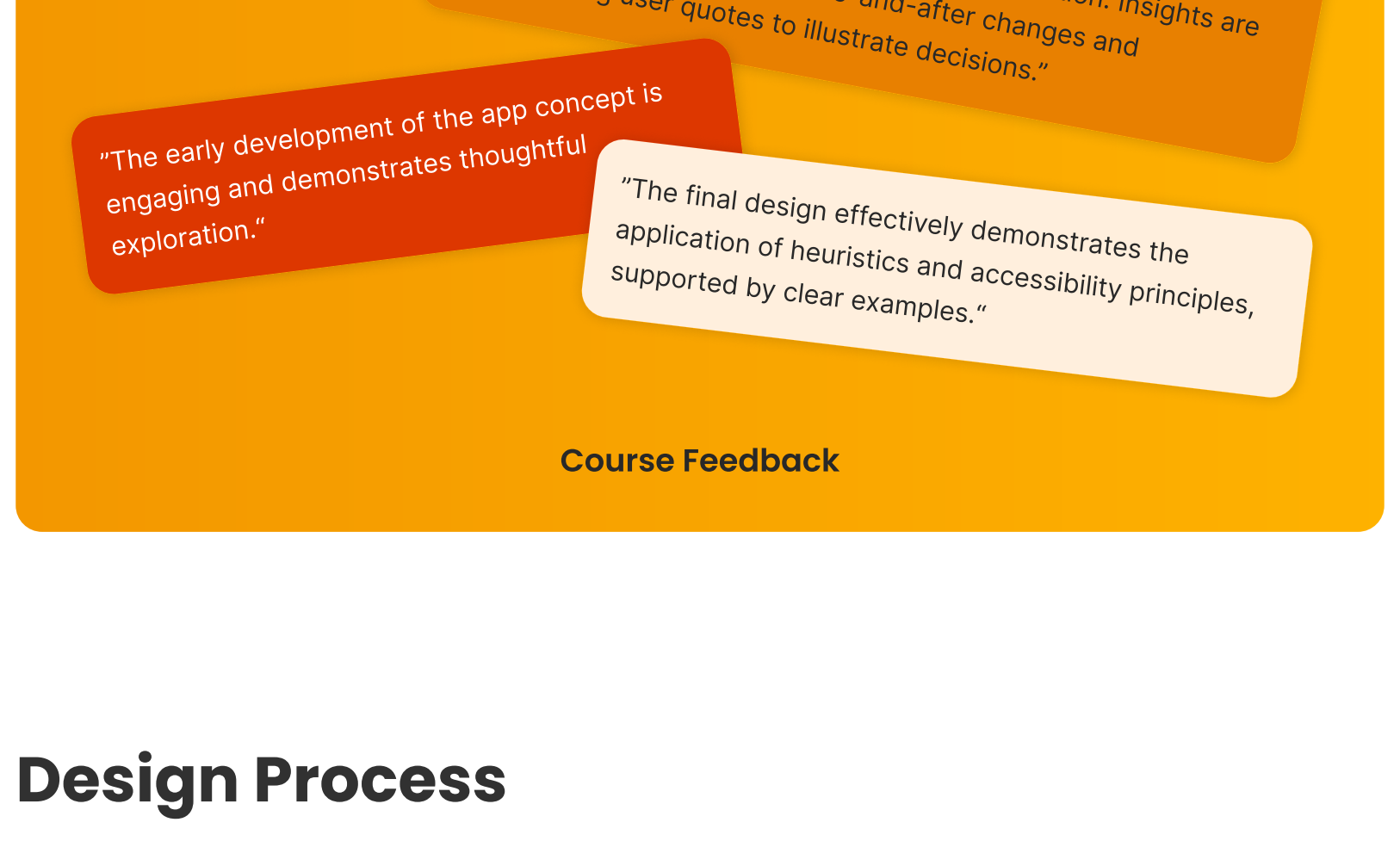
> ”The final design effectively demonstrates the application of heuristics and accessibility principles, supported by clear examples.“

Course Feedback

Design Process

A journey from understanding needs to delivering a clear, empathetic experience.

The design journey began by understanding newcomers’ pain points through research and interviews. Insights shaped design principles and reframed the challenge around trust and accessibility. From there, ideas were explored, information architecture structured, and prototypes iterated to validate usability. The final stage focused on refining navigation, clarifying flows, and crafting a high-fidelity interface that feels supportive and easy to use.



1 **Discover**
Secondary Research
Primary Research
Insights Extraction
User Journey Mapping

2 **Define**
Design Principles
Problem Reframing
HMW Questions

3 **Develop**
Platform Selection
Feature Ideation
Information Architecture
Wireframing
Prototyping
Usability Testing

4 **Deliver**
High-Fidelity Design
UI Refinement
Final Prototype
Future Validation Plan

Discover

Research combined desk analysis of rental platforms and policies with interviews of international families. Key insights revealed needs for trustworthy information, reduced search time, accurate pricing, and safe, convenient locations. Mapping the user journey exposed critical touchpoints for guidance and reassurance.

Research

In the research phase, I reviewed major rental platforms and policy resources to compare features like filters, school zones, and equipment details, while identifying risks such as scams. I also examined guidance from VUW and Tenancy Services. To complement this, I interviewed five international families, uncovering pain points around affordability, time pressure, complex applications, equipment uncertainty, and lack of trustworthy support.

Findings

F01
Trust & Verification
Hard to verify listings and avoid scams; low confidence in agents/landlords.

F02
Cost
Unexpected rental expenses strain budgets.

F03
Clarity
Pricing, furnishings, and policies are not presented clearly.

F04
Time
Long search periods often require temporary housing.

F05
Complexity
Applications are complicated and requirements unfamiliar.

F06
Support Access
Limited guidance and reliable help during the rental journey.

F07
Information Fragmentation
Key details are scattered across multiple sources.

F08
Safety & Location
Need for safe, convenient areas and suitable school zoning.

Insights

The need for a trustworthy, centralized tool; time reduction to limit buffer-period costs & anxiety; accurate pricing/equipment to manage budgets; safe, convenient locations (public transport, schools). These clarified market gaps and opportunity areas.

01
Reliability
Users want a trustworthy platform that centralizes verified listings and support information.

02
Efficiency
Reducing search and waiting time is essential to ease financial and emotional stress.

03
Accuracy
Clear pricing and equipment details help manage budgets and prevent unexpected costs.

04
Decision
amilies need guidance to make confident choices about safe, convenient housing for their needs.

User Journey

I mapped Before / During / Result / After stages (e.g., sense, search, secure, surveillance) to align actors (agents, landlords, community), tasks (inspect, compare, contact), and risks. This revealed where clear guidance and light-effort actions can sustain momentum.

Before the Journey

Users gather initial information and plan budgets, aiming to understand requirements before starting the housing search.

Phase	Sense	Search	Secure	Surveillance
Event	Understands housing challenges & risks	Browses verified listings and policies	Compares properties and schedules viewing	Tracks progress and prepares inspection
Goal	Avoid scams and unclear processes	Find suitable options for family needs	Confirm choice and secure a home	Ensure safety and finalize move-in
Thoughts	“I need clear guidance before searching.”	“Can I trust these listings and details?”	“I want to finalize without mistakes.”	“I hope everything goes smoothly.”
Feeling	Concerned	Curious	Hopeful	Confident
Pain Points	Lack of trustworthy resources	Hard to verify property details	Confusion in comparing multiple options	Unclear inspection steps
Opportunity	Clear onboarding and guidance	Transparent pricing and equipment info	Easy comparison and booking tools	Inspection checklist and reminders

After the Journey

After moving in, users reflect on the process, seek reassurance about their decisions, and consider sharing feedback for improvement.

Define

In this phase, I transformed research insights into actionable design principles and reframed the problem to focus on trust, clarity, and accessibility. These priorities set the foundation for creating a solution that feels reliable and easy to navigate.

Design Principles

From divergent thinking + interviews, we prioritized: Transparency, Clarity, Efficiency, Accessibility, Supportiveness, Inclusiveness—with explicit language about visibility, simplicity, quickness, guidance, fairness, and diversity.

Transparency
Provide clear, standardized property details (price, furnishings, lease terms) and ensure all listings and support information are verified and reliable.

Accessibility
Implement a fair, newcomer-friendly application system that minimizes barriers such as local references.

Efficiency
Optimize the rental process to reduce waiting time and financial pressure.

Inclusiveness
Support family-oriented housing decisions by filtering school zones and community factors, prioritizing safety and convenience.

Clarity
Offer accurate pricing and property details upfront to help with budgeting and ensure listed equipment is included.

Supportiveness
Centralize rental guidance, legal rights, and community resources in one platform to bridge gaps between newcomers and locals.

Problem Statement

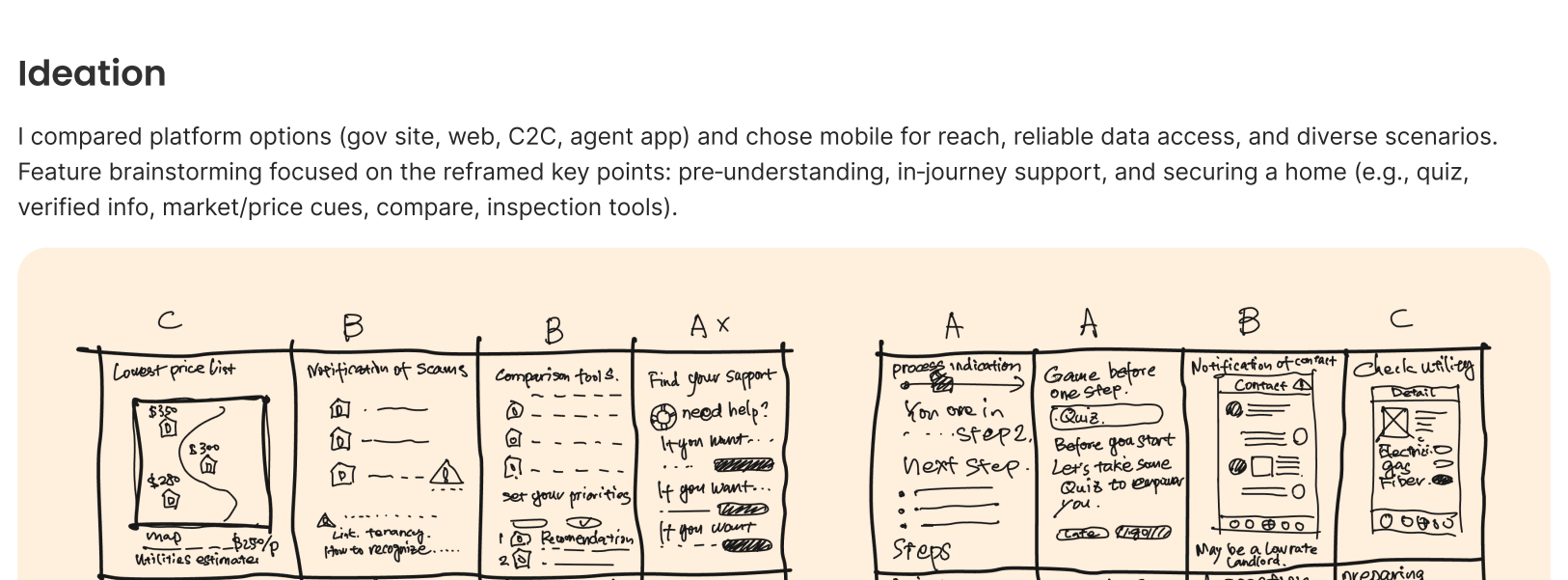
How might we equip family newcomers with a clear understanding of the housing market, rental regulations, and potential risks before their search, provide access to necessary support during challenges, and ultimately empower them to secure a home that fits their budget and family needs fairly and efficiently?

Develop

I selected mobile as the primary platform for reach and flexibility. Ideation explored features like quizzes for learning, verified listings, comparison tools, and inspection reports. Information architecture prioritized simplicity and reduced cognitive load. Prototypes evolved from sketches to mid-fi and hi-fi, with usability tests driving improvements in navigation, terminology, and layout.

Ideation

I compared platform options (gov site, web, C2C, agent app) and chose mobile for reach, reliable data access, and diverse scenarios. Feature brainstorming focused on the reframed key points: pre-understanding, in-journey support, and securing a home (e.g., quiz, verified info, market/price cues, compare, inspection tools).



Features

A Clear Understanding	B Secure a home	C Necessary support
Notification of scams	Furniture indication	Quiz
School indication	Inspection support	Lowest price list
Property rate	Comparison tool	Preparing materials
Reviews	Family option	User role

Information Architecture

I drafted IA + user flows (Home, Search, Map/Filter, Details, Support/Policies/Tools, Messages, My Path), emphasizing “do now / understand / adjust” pathways to reduce cognitive load.

- Homepage
  - Search
    - Filter
    - Map
    - Detail
  - Support
    - Policies
    - Tools
    - Help
  - Message
    - System
    - Agent
    - Landlord
  - My Path
    - Profile
    - Step
    - List
    - Reviews
    - History

Userflow for Usability test

1 Complete Step 1 Quiz in My Path

Home → My Path → Choose step → Take the Quiz → Back to Home

2 Find & Save Homes, Contact Agent

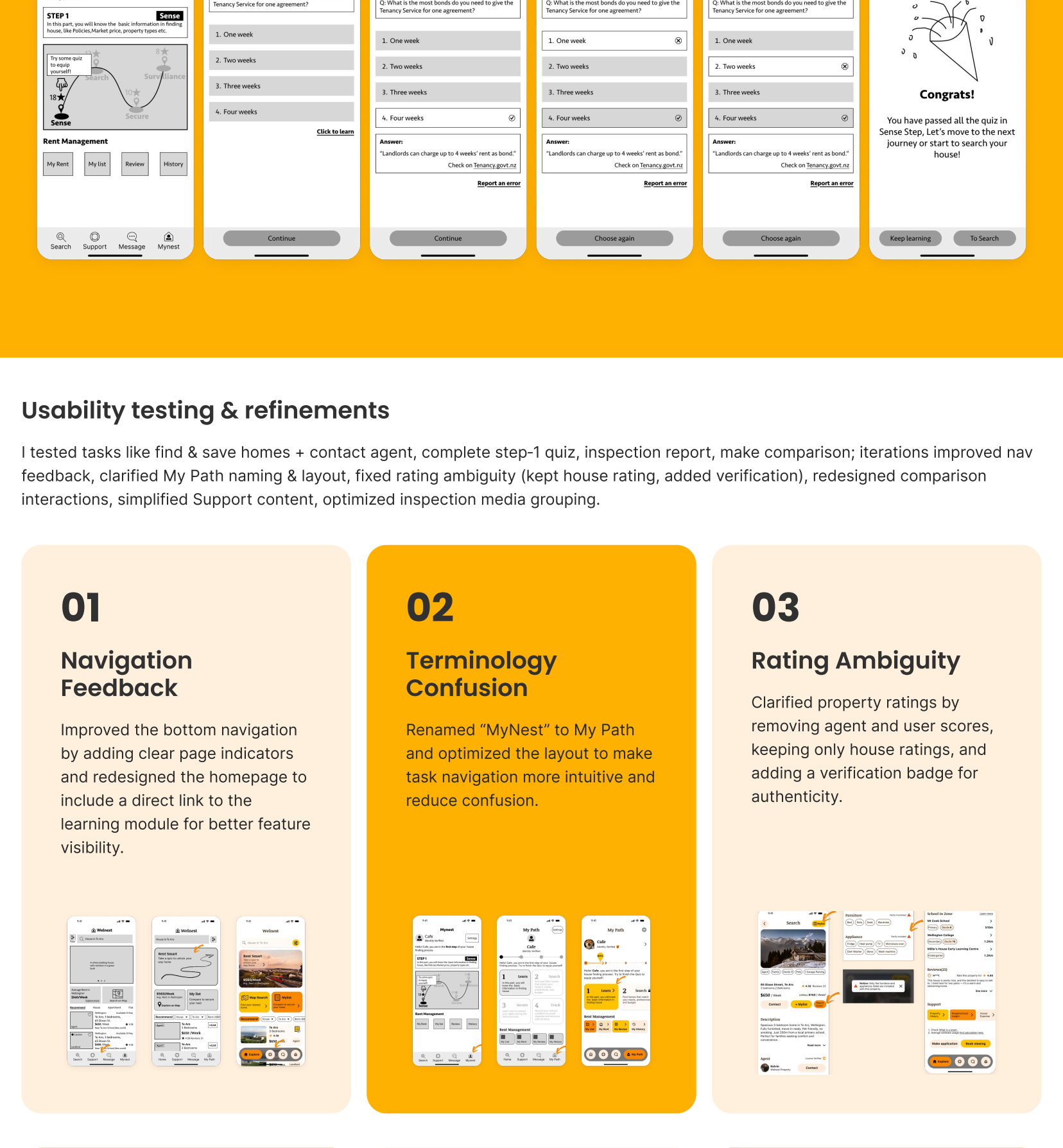
Home → Search → Filter → Add house to My list → Compare → Book viewing

3 Fill Out an Inspection Report

Home → Support → Choose Inspection Report → Preview → Generate

Prototyping

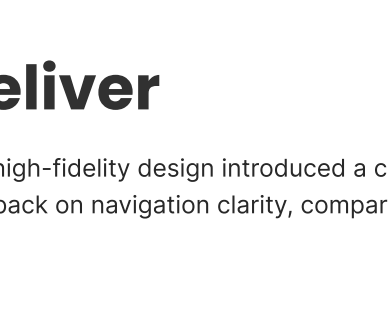
Low-/mid-fi validated concept and copy tone; we converged on one key feature per stage for clarity (e.g., quiz for understanding, map search + compare, inspection report, agent contact), then advanced to hi-fi.



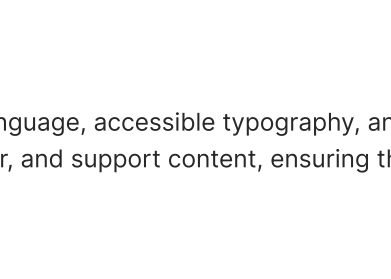
Usability testing & refinements

I tested tasks like find & save homes + contact agent, complete step-1 quiz, inspection report, make comparison; iterations improved nav feedback, clarified My Path naming & layout, fixed rating ambiguity (kept house rating, added verification), redesigned comparison interactions, simplified Support content, optimized inspection media grouping.

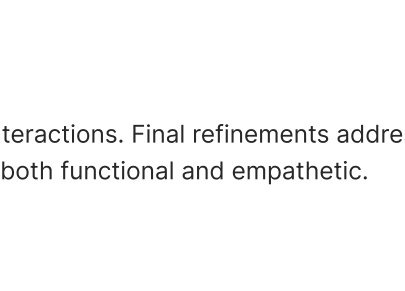
01
Navigation Feedback
Improved the bottom navigation by adding clear page indicators and redesigned the homepage to include a direct link to the learning module for better feature visibility.



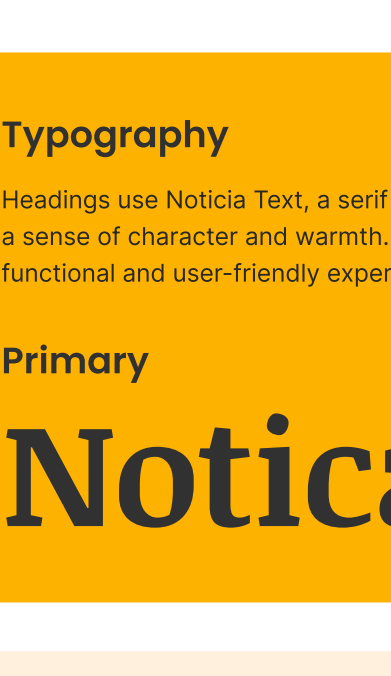
02
Terminology Confusion
Renamed “MyNest” to My Path and optimized the layout to make task navigation more intuitive and reduce confusion.



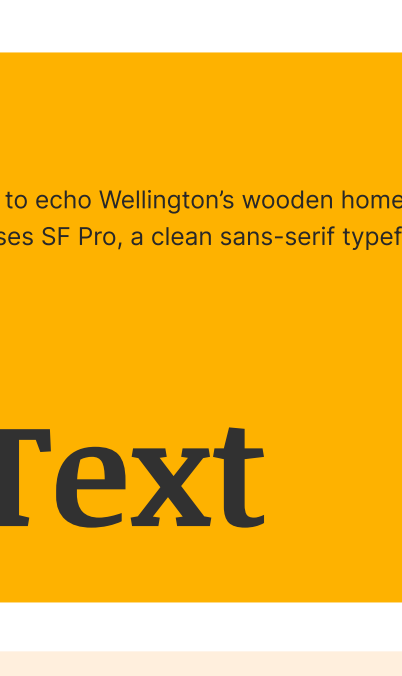
03
Rating Ambiguity
Clarified property ratings by removing agent and user scores, keeping only house ratings, and adding a verification badge for authenticity.



04
Comparison Feature
Replaced the vague “Manage” button with clear action buttons and redesigned the comparison page with horizontal scrolling for easier multi-property comparison.



05
Agent Contact
Simplified contact options by removing the “Advisor” role, adding an “All” option, and introducing a Report Scam button in the chat interface.



06
Inspection Report
Grouped similar photos into sections and added an expand-to-view option to make the inspection report page shorter and easier to navigate.

Deliver

The high-fidelity design introduced a calm visual language, accessible typography, and intuitive interactions. Final refinements addressed feedback on navigation clarity, comparison behavior, and support content, ensuring the app feels both functional and empathetic.

Design system

The Welnest design system creates a consistent and accessible experience through a unified visual language. It uses a clear color palette, structured typography, and intuitive icons to guide users. Components follow responsive layouts and standardized spacing for clarity. Interaction patterns emphasize feedback and visibility, helping users stay oriented. The system reflects principles of transparency, inclusiveness, and efficiency to support newcomers in navigating housing with confidence.

Typography

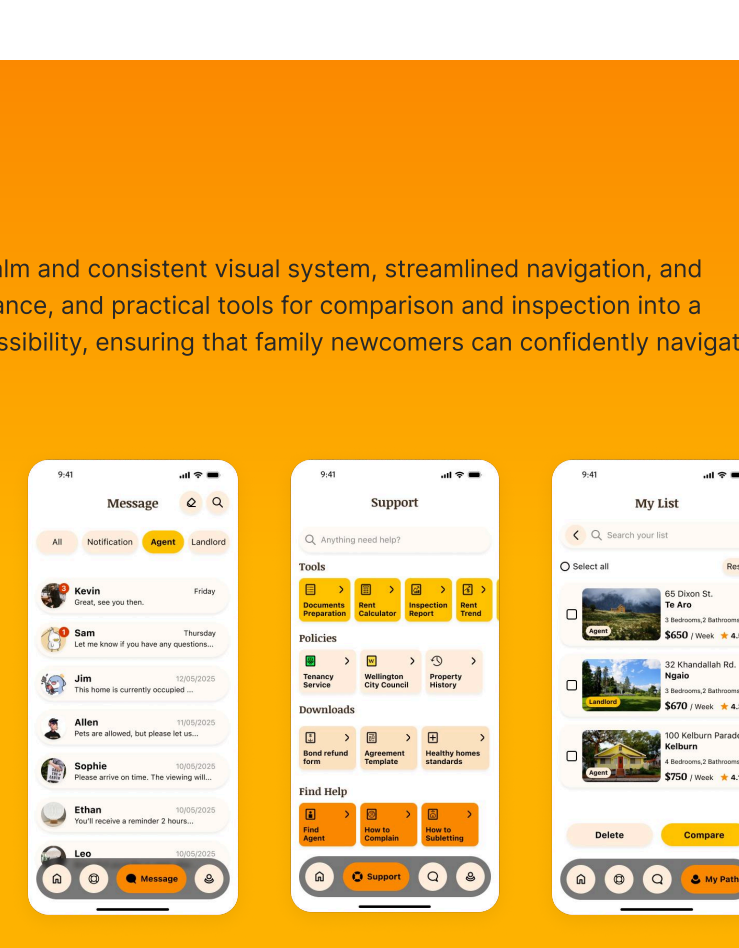
Headings use Noticia Text, a serif font chosen to echo Wellington’s wooden homes and decorative architectural details, adding a sense of character and warmth. Body text uses SF Pro, a clean sans-serif typeface for clarity and easy readability, ensuring a functional and user-friendly experience.

Primary
Notica Text

Secondary
SF Pro

Brand

The Welnest logo combines a nest and birds gradually transforming into a house, symbolizing safety and belonging. Three birds represent different user groups and the idea of family, while their placement under the roof conveys the app’s role as a guardian, providing shelter, guidance, and trust throughout the home-finding journey.



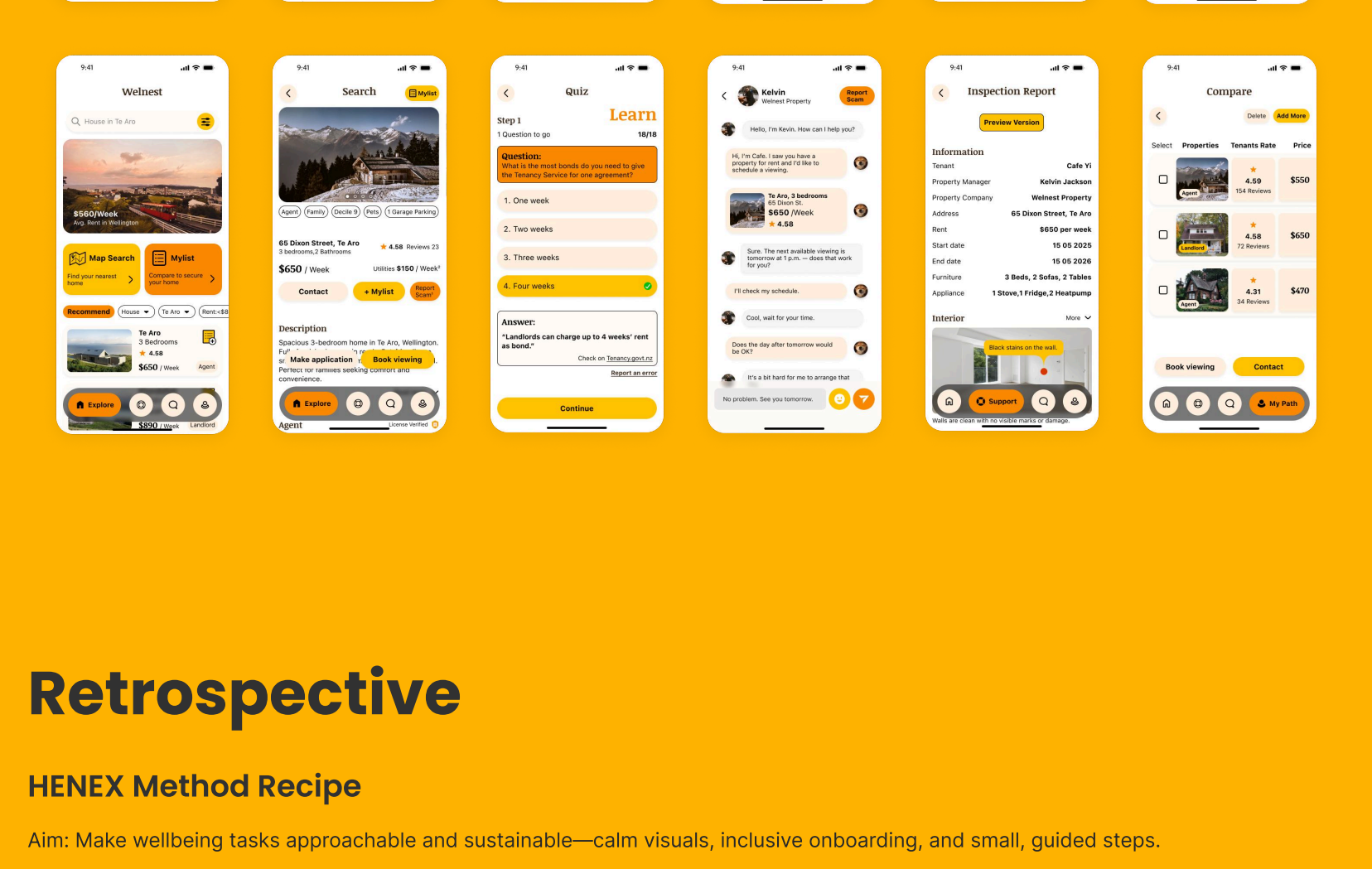
Colour

The Welnest color palette uses warm tones to create a welcoming and comforting atmosphere. Yellow serves as the primary color and orange as the secondary, symbolizing light and warmth—guiding renters on their journey to find a home.

#FFB200 · #FB8A00 · #FFEFDE

Final design

The final deliverable is a high-fidelity mobile prototype featuring a calm and consistent visual system, streamlined navigation, and intuitive flows. It organizes verified property details, contextual guidance, and practical tools for comparison and inspection into a cohesive experience. The design emphasizes clarity, trust, and accessibility, ensuring that family newcomers can confidently navigate the housing process with minimal cognitive load.



Retrospective

HENEX Method Recipe

Aim: Make wellbeing tasks approachable and sustainable—calm visuals, inclusive onboarding, and small, guided steps.

Methods:

- Purpose Story Script — Clear “why” for daily wellbeing routines.
- Calm Clarity Tuning — Low cognitive load (hierarchy/contrast/micro-feedback).
- Inclusive Onboarding Paths — Language/ability options; welcoming flows.
- Small-Step Actions — Micro-steps with confirmations to build habit.
- Impact Dashboard — Progress/milestones for motivation and retention.
- Sensory Wayfinding Map — Simple cues/icons that make finding help intuitive.

Result: Users start small, feel supported, and keep going—a gentle system that turns intention into routine.

Reflection

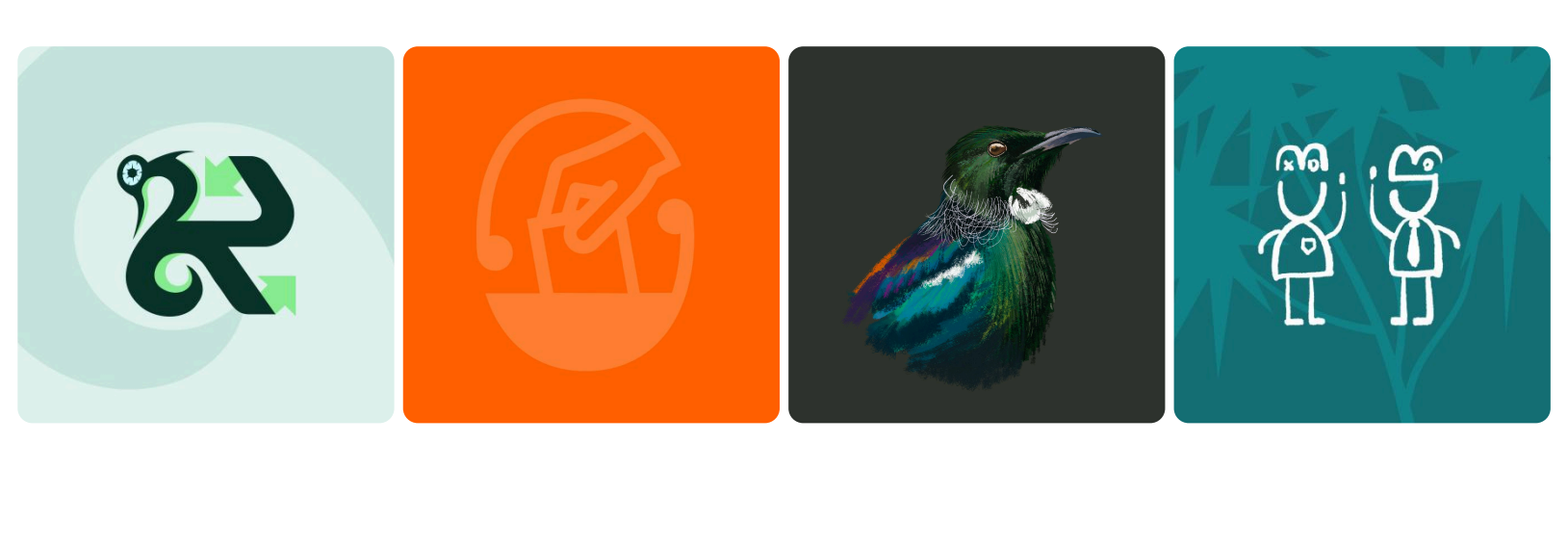
Looking back, the project’s strengths lie in its strong problem reframing, principles that guided every decision, and usability-driven refinements that improved clarity and trust. However, gaps remain in personalization depth and real-world validation, which are critical for ensuring long-term engagement and emotional impact.Strengths include strong problem reframing, principles that guided decisions, and usability-driven refinements. Gaps remain in personalization depth and real-world validation.

Next steps

Next, I will focus on validating the design with target users through usability metrics and diary studies, deepening contextual personalization, expanding accessibility checks, and implementing analytics to measure emotional outcomes and retention over time.

View Prototype

Related Projects



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Creating meaningful, experience-driven solutions that connect people, emotions, and environments.

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